DESIGN DOCUMENT · V1 · JULY 2026

Markdown Editor for macOS

A minimalist WYSIWYG markdown editor — markdown renders as you type (Typora/Bear model), with a document library sidebar, an outline panel, tabs, and rich export. Built from your four mockups. Audience: developers implementing in SwiftUI; layouts are described in terms of NavigationSplitView / adaptive columns so they port to iPadOS and iOS.

Assumptions

- App name is a placeholder ("Sample") — chrome shows document names only.
- WYSIWYG editing with syntax reveal on cursor focus (source shown for the active span).
- Multi-tab; additional windows supported, each with independent panel state.
- Content model: CommonMark + GFM tables/task lists, LaTeX math, Mermaid, footnotes, ==highlights==.

How to read this doc

- Sections 01–05 explore options — reference any badge id (e.g. `1a`) in chat to pick or remix.
- Sections 06–10 are the spec: element sheet, states, flows, responsive rules, and tokens.
- All mockups are static hi-fi; annotations in `orange mono` are implementation notes.

`01` Visual directions

Three aesthetic treatments of the same window. `1a` stays faithful to your mockups; `1b` and `1c` push warmer and starker. The structure (sidebar / editor / chrome) is identical — only tokens change.

`1a` **Graphite** — faithful to mockups · native macOS, system blue, soft grays

`1b` **Paper** — warm ivory canvas, ink text, serif headings, clay accent

`1c` **Mono** — stark white, hairline borders, square corners, single ink accent

System font (SF Pro), pure white canvas, #F5F5F7 sidebar, NSColor.controlAccentColor selection. Zero-risk, fully native feel.

New York / Iowan for headings, warm neutrals (oklch hue ≈ 80°), clay accent. Feels like a writing tool, less like an IDE.

No fills — structure from 1px hairlines. Ink-black selection, one acid highlight. Most opinionated; least "native".

The rest of this document is rendered in `1a` Graphite. Say "reflow in `1b`" to switch.

`02` App anatomy

The full window at default size (~1180×760pt) with both panels open. Three-column layout: **Library sidebar** (collapsible, 200–320pt) · **Editor** (flexible, content max-width 680pt centered) · **Outline** (collapsible, 220pt). SwiftUI: `NavigationSplitView + inspector()`.

`1d` **Annotated master window**

1 — **Library sidebar.** Folders + docs, drag-reorder. Toolbar: + new doc, ⊞ toggle sidebar (⌘0 — ⌘1–9 is reserved for tabs). Grayed items are non-md assets (images).

2 — **Tab bar.** One tab per open doc; blue dot = unsaved. ⌘T new tab, ⌘W close. Tabs hide when only one doc is open — the chrome row (format pill, outline toggle) persists.

3 — **Format pill + outline toggle (⌥⌘0).** Pill shows B/I/U + expands to full format menu on click. Floats over content when scrolled.

4 — **Outline panel.** Generated from headings; click scrolls with highlight. Current section in accent. Collapsible per-heading.

5 — **Editor.** WYSIWYG; the active line reveals raw markdown syntax. Content column max 680pt, centered, generous margins.

6 — **Status bar.** Current section + live statistics (words/chars/read time). Click stats for a detail popover. Hideable in Settings.

Glyphs: emoji in these mockups are SF Symbols placeholders — doc.text · folder · photo · ⌕ magnifyingglass · ⊞ sidebar.leading · ⊞ sidebar.trailing. Never ship emoji as icons.

`03` Sidebar treatments

Three treatments of the library. All share behavior: drag to reorder/nest, right-click context menu, inline rename, ⌘0 toggle. Widths 200–320pt, user-resizable.

`1e` **Classic tree** — faithful: icons, filled selection, disclosure chevrons

`1f` **Quiet list** — no icons, tinted-text selection, metadata on hover

`1g` **Sectioned library** — pinned area + collapsible groups

Finder-familiar. Best default; matches your mockups exactly.

Calmer, text-forward. Tinted selection (not filled) keeps focus in the editor. Doc count / edited-ago in muted mono.

Top-level folders become section headers (like Mail/Notes). Pinned docs float above. Scales best for large libraries.

Try: "use `1f` but keep the filled selection from `1e`" · "add pinned from `1g` to `1e`".

`04` Outline panel treatments

Generated live from the heading tree. Click = scroll to section; current section tracks scroll position. ⌥⌘0 toggles. Same content in all three.

`1h` **Ruled tree** — faithful: hairline under each row, chevrons

`1i` **Type-scale** — no rules, hierarchy from size + weight only

`1j` **Progress rail** — position marker tracks reading position

Your mockup. Rules make rows scannable; chevrons collapse H2 subtrees.

Quietest option — reads like a mini table of contents. No chrome at all; hover reveals a subtle row tint.

The rail shows where you are in the document (blue segment = visible viewport span). Good for long docs.

Try: "combine the rail from `1j` with the ruled rows of `1h`".

`05` Markdown text styling

Three type treatments of the same rendered markdown (your Rococo sample): **bold**, footnote^1, ==green highlight==, *italic + pink highlight*, and a spell-check underline. Body max-width 680pt; user-adjustable text size (⌘+/−) scales the whole ramp.

`1k` **Rounded** — faithful: SF Rounded feel, pill highlights, playful

`1l` **Reader serif** — New York body, bigger measure, muted marks

`1m` **Technical** — compact SF Pro, tight ramp, precise marks

SF Rounded, 15pt/1.75. Highlight colors: lime #D9F59B, pink #F7D9F0 (add yellow, blue, orange in the palette). Footnote superscript in accent.

Highlights as half-height underpainting instead of full pills — calmer for long reads. Pairs with direction `1b`.

Denser (13pt/1.6), tighter tracking, outlined highlights, bracketed footnote refs. For notes-heavy technical writing.

Try: "make `1k` the default with `1l` as a Reader mode" · "show the full element sheet in `1l`".

`06` Markdown element spec — full sheet

Every supported element, rendered in the `1a` / `1k` default style, with type + spacing tokens in the margin. This is the source of truth for the renderer.

`1n` **Element sheet**

`07` Interaction states

Row, tab, and document states. All transitions 150ms ease-out; drag uses the system lift shadow.

`1o` **State matrix**

`08` Key flows

Storyboards for the three core journeys. Frames are simplified; interaction details reference section `1o`.

`1p` **Flow storyboards**

New document
⌘N

Organize
drag

Export
⇧⌘E

Sheet slides from titlebar (native `.sheet`). PDF uses print stylesheet from the element sheet `1n`; mermaid/math rasterized @2x. HTML embeds assets inline. MD export = copy of source + asset folder. Live thumbnail preview on the right edge (omitted here).

`09` Responsive behavior & platform ports

One layout system, three size classes. Panels collapse in priority order (outline first, then sidebar). The editor column never exceeds 680pt of text measure regardless of window width.

`1q` **Size classes + ports**

`≥ 900pt · all three columns`

`560–900pt · outline auto-hides (⌥⌘0 overlays it)`

`< 560pt · editor only; panels overlay with scrim`

Format pill collapses to a single **Aa** button under 700pt. Tab bar switches to a compact popup menu under 560pt. Status bar drops statistics first, section name last. All thresholds are on the editor column width, not the window — so a wide window with both panels open behaves like a narrow one.

Port rules. All view models are platform-free (the AST + SessionStore core). Only navigation containers and the format-control surface differ per platform. Highlight/callout/code tokens are shared asset-catalog colors, so dark mode + iOS come for free.

`iPadOS · same NavigationSplitView; outline via trailing inspector; pencil-friendly 44pt rows`

`iOS · push nav (library → doc); outline = bottom sheet; format bar docks above keyboard`

`10` Design tokens — SwiftUI handoff

Tokens for the `1a` Graphite direction. Name them as asset-catalog colors / a `Theme` struct; the `1b` / `1c` directions are alternate values for the same keys.

`1r` **Token sheet**

Next steps: pick a direction from 01 + one option each from 03/04/05 (e.g. "`1a` + `1e` + `1h` + `1k`") and I'll produce the consolidated master mockups, dark mode, and a clickable prototype · or ask for "more variations of ‹section›".